Ethan O'Leary

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Education

Norwegian School of Economics (NHH), Bergen, Norway,
PhD Economics, Supervisor: Erik Ø. Sørensen *(2022-2026)*

Wissenschaftszentrum Berlin für Sozialforschung (WZB) & Humboldt University, Berlin, Germany
Research stay hosted by Prof. Dr. Dorothea Kübler & Prof. Sebastian Schweighofer-Kodritsch PhD *(April-July 2025)*

Stockholm School of Economics, Stockholm, Sweden
MSc Economics: GPA 4.47/5.0 *(2019-2022)*

University of Newcastle-upon-Tyne, Newcastle-upon-Tyne, United Kingdom
BSc Economics with Study Abroad: First Class with Honours *(2015-2019)*

References

Prof. Erik Øiolf Sørensen.
Norwegian School of Economics
erik.sorensen@nhh.no

Prof. Sebastian Schweighofer-Kodritsch.
Universität Leipzig
sebastian.schweighofer-kodritsch@uni-leipzig.de

Prof. Bertil Tungodden.
Norwegian School of Economics
bertil.tungodden@nhh.no

Placement Director: Björn Brey, bjorn.brey@nhh.no.

Teaching and Research Fields

Behavioural Economics, Microeconomic Theory, Applied Microeconomics.

Job Market Paper

(Mis)anticipated Discrimination *Paper Access*
Awards: Best Paper Award at The Young Economists' Meeting 2026

I propose and test a novel mechanism through which discrimination persists: the misperception of statistical discrimination as taste-based discrimination. I first derive a model of self-confirming discrimination in a job-application setting, in which misperceiving statistical discrimination as taste-based is a key channel: correctly attributed statistical discrimination admits both discriminatory and non-discriminatory equilibria, so inequality reflects a coordination failure, while misattribution to taste-based origins yields only discriminatory equilibria and lowers the perceived return to re-coordination. In a pre-registered laboratory experiment, subjects who experience discrimination from an ambiguous origin overestimate the probability that this inequality is caused by taste-based discriminators. This misattribution is associated with a higher probability that application strategies sustain statistical discrimination: a 1 percentage point increase in believed probability that discrimination is taste-based corresponds to a 0.35 (0.24) percentage point decrease (increase) in the probability that a subject in the discriminated (favoured) group applies to a job, perpetuating statistical discrimination. Moreover, the more likely subjects perceive the employer to be a taste-based discriminator, the more unfair they perceive the labour market and the lower their demand for a temporary affirmative action policy aimed at re-coordinating toward a less discriminatory outcome. This demonstrates that the persistence of discrimination is not only driven by the underlying source, but also the perception of such.

Working Papers

The Cultural Trust Gap: Discrimination Across England's North-South Divide
Working Paper Access (Under review)

Trust, the belief in another individual or organisation's intent to act in good faith, is a cornerstone of social prosperity. However, cultural norms significantly influence trust levels within and between groups, often leading to discriminatory behaviours that undermine cooperation. This paper investigates the impact of culture on trust using a novel experimental approach that isolates trust from confounding factors such as risk preferences and distributional concerns. The setting of the experiment is England, a culturally and economically divided nation. Focusing on self-identified Southerners and Northerners, I find evidence of a cultural trust gap. Specifically, while Southerners exhibit equal trust towards both groups, Northerners trust Southerners significantly less than their own group. By decomposing trust into its conditional and unconditional components, I show that this disparity is driven by unconditional trust: Northerners perceive Southerners as more selfish than their own culture.

Works in Progress

Expecting Bias: How Beliefs of Discrimination Shape The Gender Application Gap *(with Roberto Caputo, Michael Hilweg-Waldeck & Anita Zednik)*

We study to what extent including evaluator subjectivity in tournament decisions affects the documented gender gap in competition. We conduct a large-scale, pre-registered online experiment ($n = 7310$) in which workers choose between a non-competitive piece rate and a competitive payment scheme whose payout depends on being selected by an incentivised human evaluator. By randomly varying whether the evaluator can observe the worker's gender across a male-stereotyped and a non-stereotyped task, we exogenously induce the scope for anticipated discrimination. In the male-stereotyped task, gender revelation breaks the link between women's objective performance beliefs and their beliefs about being selected: conditional on the subjective probability of having the best signal, moderately confident women report significantly lower selection expectations when their gender is observable. This distortion reduces female entry, especially among non-risk-averse participants, who had dominated the competitor pool under concealed gender. Revelation also disproportionately affects low-ability women, destabilising the usual negative ability-competition relationship among females. We validate that this effect is driven by the anticipation of gender discrimination and not by a preference for opting out of settings in which gender is made salient: in a non-stereotyped task we find no change in beliefs nor in competition behaviour when their gender is revealed to the evaluator. Our findings suggest that the extent to which the gender competition gap distorts female labour supply may be underestimated in the face of the potential for evaluator bias, even before it is enacted.

The Fairness of Discrimination (*with Erik Ø. Sørensen & Sebastian Schweighofer-Kodritsch*)

Revisiting Trust in Unequal Societies: Experimental Evidence (*with Roberto Caputo*)

The Archaeology of Discrimination (*with Ashley McCrea*)

Teaching

Undergraduate
Economics and Psychology (Autumn 2026 [Lecturer])
Microeconomics (Autumn 2020 & 2021 [TA])

Graduate
Behavioral Economics (Spring 2026 [Lecturer]: Autumn 2026, Autumn 2025, Spring 2024 & Autumn 2023 [TA])
Behavioral Business Strategy (Autumn 2024 [TA])
Introduction to the Global Economy (Autumn 2022 [Lecturer])

Grants

2026
German Association for Experimental Economics Research, 2 000 EUR *(with Roberto Caputo, Michael Hilweg-Waldeck & Anita Zednik)*
ZEW Research funds, 3 800 EUR *(with Roberto Caputo, Michael Hilweg-Waldeck & Anita Zednik)*

2025
Norwegian School of Economics Centre for Ethics Grant, 30 000 NOK *(with Roberto Caputo)*
Norwegian School of Economics Centre for Ethics Grant, 30 000 NOK
University of Mannheim Economics Department, 50 000 EUR *(with Roberto Caputo, Michael Hilweg-Waldeck & Anita Zednik)*
Professor Wilhelm Keilhaus Minnefond, 50 000 NOK
Norges Banks Fond til Økonomisk Forskning, 20 000 NOK

2024
Norwegian School of Economics Centre for Ethics Grant, 20 000 NOK

Conferences & Workshops

Upcoming
Copenhagen Network of Experimental Economists, Lund; 2027 ASSA Meeting (Session from Association for the Society of Generosity), Washington DC

2026
Young Economists Meeting, Brno; 3rd Annual Workshop on Behavioural Economics, Sheffield; FUR Conference, Alicante, The Chicago School in Experimental Economics, Osaka; 2nd Berlin Micro Theory & Behavioural Economics Conference, Berlin; EEA 2026, Dublin; 6th Discrimination and Diversity Workshop, Online; NYU Abu Dhabi Behavioral and Experimental Economics Job Market Workshop;

2025
Newcastle University Experimental Economics Meeting, Newcastle-upon-Tyne; Max Planck / FAIR NHH Workshop, Bonn; Berlin Micro Theory and Behavioral Economics PhD Conference, Berlin; Society for Advancement of Behavioral Economics (SABE), Trento; Berlin-Bergen Behavioral Workshop, Berlin; Thurgau Experimental Economics Meeting, Kreuzlingen

2024
Copenhagen Network of Experimental Economics, Lund; FAIR Spring School, UC San Diego

Invited Talks

2025
University of Mannheim

Service

Referee: Journal of Political Economy Microeconomics

Other Experience

Quantify Research, Stockholm, Sweden
Research Analyst in Real World Evidence (Health economics) *(2022)*

Stockholm Institute for Transition Economics (SITE), Stockholm, Sweden
Research Assistant to Prof. Jesper Roine *(2021-2022)*

Skills

Software
Stata, R, Python, oTree, Javascript, HTML

Languages
English (native), French (advanced), Swedish (intermediate), Spanish (beginner)